PART I

Pitch

Every note is higher or lower than another. This part starts with the keyboard you can see and touch, moves to the staff where those keys are written, and ends with the families of notes, scales and keys, that whole pieces are built from.

1 **Keyboard** high and low, the patterns › 2 **Staff** lines, spaces and clefs › 3 **Note names** reading every note › 4 **Sharps and flats** the black keys › 5 **Intervals** the distance between notes › 6 **Scales and keys** notes in families

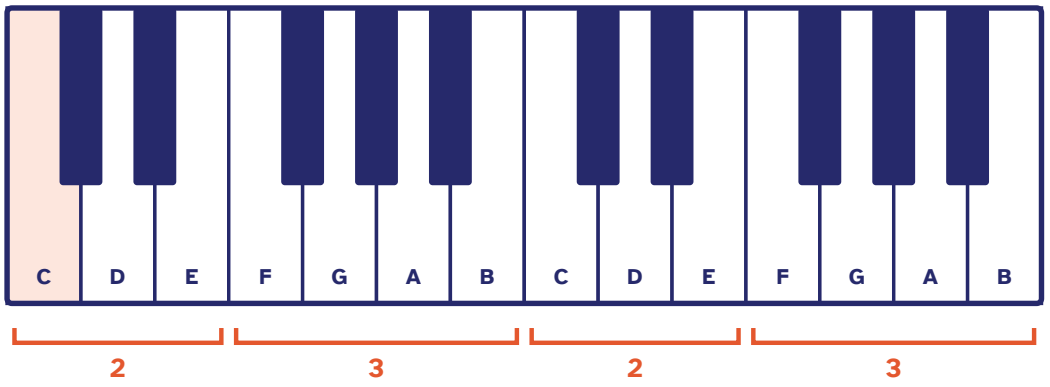
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PART I · PITCH · 1

The keyboard

Keys to the **left** sound **lower**; keys to the **right** sound **higher**. The black keys come in groups of **two** and **three**, and that pattern repeats all the way along: it is how you find every note.



The white keys

The white keys are named with seven letters, **A B C D E F G**, then the letters start again. **C** is the white key just left of each group of two black keys; **F** is just left of each group of three.

Middle C and octaves

Middle C is the C nearest the middle of the keyboard, usually right in front of you. From one C to the next is an **octave**: eight white keys, counting both. A full piano has 88 keys, from A at the bottom to C at the top.

Words to know

TERM	MEANING	FIRST MET
pitch	how high or low a sound is	Level 0
octave	the distance from one note to the next with the same name (8 white keys)	Level 0
semitone	from one key to the very next key, black or white	Level 0
tone	two semitones	Level 0
register	a part of the keyboard: low, middle or high	Level 0

WATCH OUT

- × Finding C by counting from the bottom: find a group of two black keys and look just to the left.
- × Calling every white-to-white step a tone: E–F and B–C have no black key between them, so they are semitones.

SEE ALSO

The staff p. 23 · Tones and semitones p. 26

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Level 0 · Keyboard · Online: Keyboard patterns, Musical alphabet

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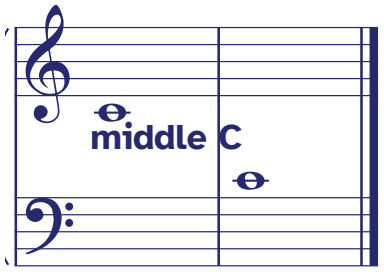
The staff and the clefs

Music is written on a **staff** (or stave) of five lines and four spaces. Lines and spaces are counted from the **bottom**. Higher notes sit higher on the staff. A **clef** at the start tells you which notes the lines and spaces stand for.

CLEF	NAME	HOW IT SHOWS ITS NOTE	FIRST MET
𝄞	**treble clef** (G clef)	curls round the line for G (line 2)	Level 0
𝄢	**bass clef** (F clef)	its two dots sit either side of the line for F (line 4)	Level 0
𝄡	**alto clef** (C clef)	its centre marks middle C, on line 3	Level 2

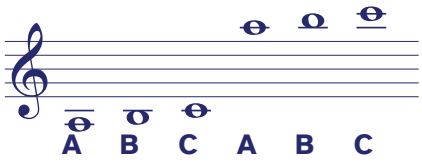
The grand staff

Piano music uses two staves joined by a brace: the treble staff, usually for the right hand, above the bass staff, usually for the left. **Middle C** sits between them on a short line of its own, and can be written in either staff.



Ledger lines

Notes above or below the staff are written on short extra lines called **ledger lines**, spaced exactly like the staff lines.



Octave signs

SIGN	MEANING
8va	play an octave higher than written; a dotted line shows how long
8vb	play an octave lower
15ma	play two octaves higher
loco	back where it is written

Level ½. Octave signs save writing many ledger lines.

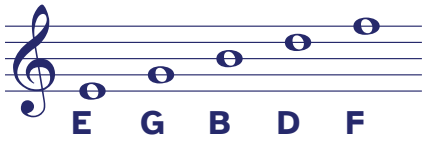
SEE ALSO
Reading the notes p. 24

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Level 0 · The staff · Online: Library › Staff and clefs

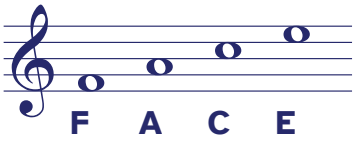
PART I · PITCH · 3

Reading the notes

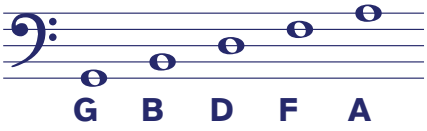
Each line and space has one letter name. Learn them in two ways: by the patterns below, and by a few **landmark notes** you can find instantly and count from.



Treble clef: the lines



Treble clef: the spaces



Bass clef: the lines

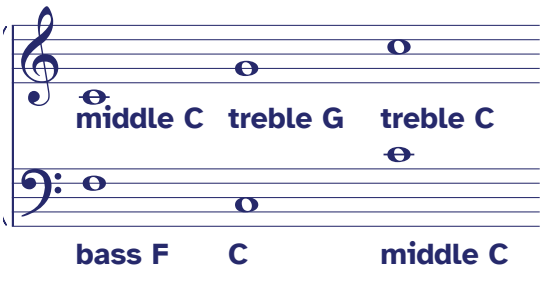


Bass clef: the spaces

STAFF	NOTES, BOTTOM TO TOP	TO REMEMBER
Treble lines	E G B D F	*Every Good Boy Deserves Fun*
Treble spaces	F A C E	spells *FACE*
Bass lines	G B D F A	*Great Big Dragon Flies Away*
Bass spaces	A C E G	*All Cows Eat Grass*

Landmark notes

Find these first: middle C, the G the treble clef curls round, the F between the bass clef's dots. Any other note is a step or a skip away. A **step** moves from a line to the next space (or space to line); a **skip** jumps from line to line or space to space.



WATCH OUT

- × Reading the bass clef with treble names: the same position has a different name in each clef.
- × Counting lines from the top: always count from the bottom.

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Sharps, flats and naturals

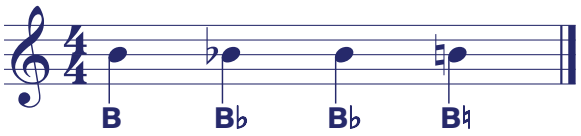
An **accidental** written before a note changes its pitch by a semitone. On the keyboard, a sharp usually means the black key to the right, a flat the black key to the left.

SIGN	NAME	WHAT IT DOES	FIRST MET
♯	sharp	raises a note by a semitone	Level 0
♭	flat	lowers a note by a semitone	Level 0
♮	natural	cancels a sharp or flat	Level ½
𝄪	double sharp	raises by two semitones	Level 4
𝄫	double flat	lowers by two semitones	Level 4

An accidental lasts for the bar



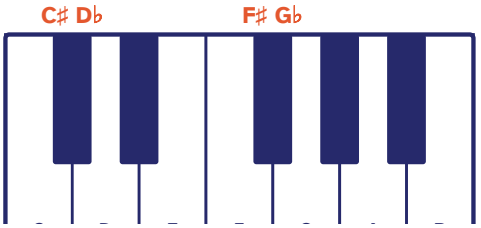
The sharp still counts later in the bar; after the bar line, F is F again.



A natural cancels the flat for the rest of the bar.

One key, two names

Every black key has two names: the key between F and G is both **F♯** and **G♭**. Notes that sound the same but are written differently are **enharmonic**. White keys can have sharp or flat names too: **E♯** is F, **C♭** is B.



WATCH OUT

- × Forgetting that an accidental carries on through the bar.
- × Thinking every sharp is a black key: E♯ and B♯ are white keys.

SEE ALSO

Keys and key signatures p. 28

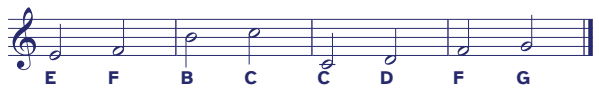
PRACTISE IT

Workbook Levels 0–½ · Accidentals · Online: Library › Signs

PART I · PITCH · 5

Tones, semitones and intervals

A **semitone** is the very next key; a **tone** is two semitones. An **interval** is the distance between two notes. Its **number** comes from counting letter names, both ends included; its **quality** from counting semitones.



E–F and B–C are semitones; C–D and F–G are tones.



Melodic: one note after the other. Harmonic: together.

Interval numbers from C



Size in semitones

NUMBER	SMALLER	MAIN	WIDER	FIRST MET
unison	0			Level 1
2nd	1 (minor)	2 (major)		Level 1
3rd	3 (minor)	4 (major)		Level ½
4th		5 (perfect)	6 (augmented)	Level 1
5th	6 (diminished)	7 (perfect)		Level 1
6th	8 (minor)	9 (major)		Level 2
7th	10 (minor)	11 (major)		Level 2
octave		12 (perfect)		Level 1

Augmented: a semitone wider than major or perfect. Diminished: a semitone narrower than minor or perfect (Level 5). Six semitones is the tritone. Turned upside down, the numbers add to 9 and major and minor swap.

SEE ALSO
Scales p. 27 · Chords p. 50

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Levels 1–2 · Intervals · Online: Library › Intervals

PART I · PITCH · 6

Scales

A **scale** is a ladder of notes from one key note up to the next, in a fixed pattern of tones (T) and semitones (S). The pattern, not the starting note, makes a scale major or minor.



C major: T T S T T T S. The semitones fall between 3–4 and 7–8.

SCALE	STEPS	FIRST MET
major	T T S T T T S	Level ½
natural minor	T S T T S T T	Level ½
harmonic minor	T S T T S T+S S	Level ½
melodic minor (up)	T S T T T T S; down as the natural minor	Level 2
chromatic	every semitone	Level 2
pentatonic (black keys)	T T T+S T T+S	Level 0

A minor in three forms



Natural: the notes of C major, from A to A.



Harmonic: the 7th raised a semitone (G♯).



Melodic: 6th and 7th raised going up, lowered coming down.

Degree names

1 tonic · **2** supertonic · **3** mediant · **4** subdominant · **5** dominant · **6** submediant · **7** leading note

Relative major and minor

Every major key shares its notes and key signature with a minor key three semitones lower: its **relative minor**. C major and A minor; G major and E minor.

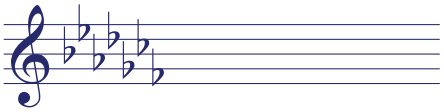
PART I · PITCH · 7

Keys and key signatures

A **key signature** at the start of each line lists the sharps or flats the piece uses throughout, so they do not have to be written before every note. They always appear in the same order.



Sharps: F C G D A E B. The key note is a semitone above the last sharp.



Flats: B E A D G C F. From two flats, the second-last flat names the key.

MAJOR	RELATIVE MINOR	SIGNATURE	FIRST MET
C major	A minor	—	Level ½
G major	E minor	1♯	Level ½
D major	B minor	2♯	Level 1
A major	F♯ minor	3♯	Level 3
E major	C♯ minor	4♯	Level 4
B major	G♯ minor	5♯	Level 4
F major	D minor	1♭	Level ½
B♭ major	G minor	2♭	Level 1
E♭ major	C minor	3♭	Level 3
A♭ major	F minor	4♭	Level 4
D♭ major	B♭ minor	5♭	Level 4

Six and seven sharps or flats (F♯, C♯, G♭, C♭ major and their minors) come at Levels 4–6.

WATCH OUT

- × Forgetting the key signature halfway down the page: it applies to every line and every octave.
- × Naming a minor key from its signature alone: check the last note and look for a raised 7th.

SEE ALSO

Scales p. 27 · Related keys p. 30

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Levels ½–4 · Keys · Online: Scale finder, Library › Keys